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southland - Many fall races may be virtually decided - Majority of House, state contests not competitive

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In a political fantasy world, the November election in Southern California would feature close, hotly debated races that present voters with strong options for choosing fresh leaders and new directions — or to stick with old ones — for the nation and state.

In reality, such races are few and far between.

While five congressional elections in Orange and Los Angeles counties will make headlines as pivotal in the national fight over which major party controls the House of Representatives, the vast majority of U.S. House and state legislative races do not appear to be competitive. That's true even after previous signs of rising competitiveness following major voting reforms that took effect earlier this decade.

"Most, by definition, tend to be over in the primary," said Jim Brulte, chairman of the California Republican Party, which has only a long-shot chance — or no chance at all — to win in the many Southern California districts where Democratic voters enjoy majorities.

With June 5 primary results all but official, the Southern California News Group reviewed the results in 79 elections for the U.S. House and the California Assembly and Senate in districts that touch Los Angeles, Orange, Riverside and San Bernardino counties to see how many races might be considered competitive in the Nov. 6 general election.

Among the findings:

• Most races were dominated by incumbents. In only 13 races (16 percent) did candidates from the incumbent party total less than 55 percent of the vote. In only two races did the incumbent party receive less than 50 percent of the vote, those being the 49th House District, where eight Republicans among 16 candidates to replace Darrell Issa, D-Vista, received a total of 48 percent of the vote, and the 60th Assembly District, where Democrat Sabrina Cervantes of Riverside got 46.9 percent as the lone Democrat in a two-person primary.

• Voter registration numbers drive primary results. In only three districts where Democrats outnumbered Republicans in the most recent registration report did Republicans get more votes: Cervantes' district; the 25th House District,

where Steve Knight, R-Santa Clarita, is running for re-election; and the 34th Senate District, where Janet Nguyen, R-Fountain Valley, seeks re-election. And in only one district where Republicans outnumber Democrats in voter registration did Democrats get more votes: Issa's district.

• Southern California is so blue that 23 ballots in November will have no Republican while at least one Democrat will appear on every two-person ballot. In all but two cases, there's no GOP name on the ballot because none ran in the primary, leaving a lone Democrat, or two Democrats, or a Democrat and a third-party or independent candidate, to advance under California's top two primary system. The two exceptions to this are the 44th House District, where Republicans Jazmina Saavedra and Stacey Dash (who had quit the race) were beaten by Democrat Aja Brown (who also had stopped campaigning) for the second spot on the ballot beside Rep. Nanette Diaz Barragán, D-San Pedro, and the 54th Assembly District, where two Democrats, Assemblywoman Sydney Kamlager and candidate Tepring Piquado, finished in the top two spots ahead of Republican Glen Ratcliff.

The statistics suggest 2018 features slightly more competitive elections than what voters were presented with in 2014, the last time all of the same districts were on the ballot.

Four years ago, 11 primaries saw incumbent parties receiving 55 percent or less of the vote and a dozen November elections produced similarly close results. Of greater significance, perhaps, is that if the parties' vote percentages on June 5 of this year are replicated on Nov. 6, the four-county area will feature far more competitive races than the region had in 2010, when only five November elections saw incumbent parties' candidates earn 55 percent or less.

Political scientists and campaign professionals caution that primary results don't always predict general election results, because November elections historically draw more voters, mostly more Democratic voters. But several agreed that, as is usually the case, competitive races are more the exception than the rule. Most say it's a less than ideal landscape, but a fact of life that's become entrenched for two reasons. First, Democrats hold majorities in Los Angeles, Riverside and San Bernardino counties, and they're poised to overtake Republicans in Orange County, during an era when it is increasingly rare for voters to stray out of their political tribes. Second, incumbents enjoy huge advantages when it comes to re-election campaigning.

"When you get too far out of balance, the rights of the minority get, if not trampled, then lost in the shuffle," said Tom Hogen-Esch, a Cal State Northridge political science professor. "I would prefer to see districts more evenly matched in terms of partisan representation, just so people feel they have a stake in the democracy."

The problem is acute for some voters near Cal State Northridge. In November, they'll vote in what are expected to be one-sided elections for the 30th House District (where Rep. Brad Sherman, D-Sherman Oaks, is the incumbent), 18th state Senate District (Bob Hertzberg, D-Van Nuys) and 45th Assembly District (Jesse Gabriel, D-Encino).

Nearby, though, Santa Clarita voters are presented with likely-to-be-competitive races in the 25th House District (Knight vs. Democrat Katie Hill) and 38th Assembly District (Dante Acosta, R-Santa Clarita, vs. Democrat Christy Smith).

Experts say it's unclear how electoral competition is being affected by recent changes in California voting law. Those changes include the 2010 introduction of the so-called jungle primary system, in which the top two finishers in the primary move on to the November general election regardless of party affiliation.

Other changes include term limits for many state lawmakers and voting districts that have been redrawn by a nonpartisan citizens' commission.

Bob Stern, former president of the Center for Governmental Studies and general counsel for the California Fair Political Practices Commission, gives the new redistricting procedure, which took effect with the 2012 election, credit for producing a fairer playing field.

But Eric Bauman, chairman of the California Democratic Party, said he thinks the effect of redistricting is overrated. Fairer districts, he said, have only guaranteed that Democrats' majority among L.A.-area voters gets its way at the polls.

Mac Zilber, an L.A.-area campaign consultant for Democratic candidates, said one reason so many state legislative races appear noncompetitive is that more-lenient term limits mean there are fewer open seats in 2018.

At the congressional level, meanwhile, Zilber believes the statistics from the recent primary confirm his impression of the state of play in Southern California: Shifting voter demographics give Democrats a chance to capture the Republican-held House seats held by Knight, by Mimi Walters, R-Laguna Beach, in District 45, and by Dana Rohrabacher, R-Huntington Beach, in District 48, and by the retiring Issa and Ed Royce, R-Brea, in District 39.

But "outside of those, we're seeing a lot fewer competitive House seats," Zilber said.

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